GRC205 ASSIGNMENT

GOVERNANCE, RISK & COMPLIANCE · CYBER INCIDENT OPERATIONAL BRIEFING

Crisis Communication & Stakeholder Management

Response Pack

Ransomware-suspected file-share outage during payroll week

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1. Executive Summary

This Response Pack provides a complete, deploy-able crisis-communication framework for a high-consequence cyber incident: the sudden unavailability of a critical file share at 08:15 on a Monday, with ransomware suspected but unconfirmed, and payroll processing due on Friday. An unverified screenshot is already circulating inside and outside the organization.

The pack establishes a single source of truth, maps five priority stakeholder cohorts with distinct needs and owners, and delivers the first four-hour communication cycle (08:30 – 12:30). All messages rigorously separate confirmed facts from unknowns. No claim is made that the event is ransomware, that data has or has not been exposed, or that Friday's payroll will proceed as normal. Out-of-band channels are defined so communications can continue even if corporate systems are compromised or offline.

The approach prioritizes factual discipline over premature reassurance. An unverified promise on payroll would damage long-term trust more than a disciplined admission that certain variables remain unknown. Escalation to external or regulatory audiences is reserved for confirmed thresholds only. The pack is designed so a crisis team could hand the materials directly to the relevant audiences under live operational pressure.

2. Lab Objectives

The core learning objective of GRC205 is to master the discipline of communicating under uncertainty. Specific objectives addressed in this Response Pack are:

a. Separate confirmed telemetry from speculative chatter.
b. Establish reliable out-of-band communication loops that survive loss of corporate systems.
c. Protect organizational integrity by avoiding premature attribution, false promises and speculative claims.
d. Maintain stakeholder trust through audience-specific, calm and actionable messaging.
e. Demonstrate professional judgement in balancing speed of response against accuracy and legal exposure.

3. Tools and Resources Used

a. GRC205 Assignment Brief - Crisis Communication & Stakeholder Management (scenario, deliverables and rubric).
b. UK National Cyber Security Centre (NCSC) - Guidance on effective communications in a cyber incident.
c. CISA #StopRansomware Guide and joint guidance on outage communications and out-of-band channels.
d. NIST SP 800-61 and related incident-response communication principles.
e. Industry practice on holding statements, stakeholder tier and escalation thresholds under ransomware pressure.

4. One-Page Incident Communication Plan

First four-hour operational window: 08:30 - 12:30. Plan owner: Communications Lead (reporting to Incident Commander).

Authorized spokespersons: Incident Commander (technical/operational), Communications Lead (all external and workforce messaging), Legal Counsel (privilege-protected and regulatory).

Governing principles

a. Only confirmed telemetry is stated as fact.
b. Speculation, attribution, data-exposure claims and recovery timelines are prohibited until verified by the Incident Commander and cleared by Legal.
c. All messages travel through pre-authenticated out-of-band channels first.
d. A single source of truth is maintained; no parallel narratives.

Table 1. First communication cycle (08:30–12:30)

Order	Time	Audience	Purpose	Owner	Channel
1	08:30 – 09:00	Incident Command + technical leads	Single source of truth, spokespersons, disclosure hygiene	Communications Lead + Incident Cdr	Secure bridge / encrypted group
2	09:00 – 09:45	All employees	Holding statement, operational rules, address screenshot	Communications Lead	Out-of-band SMS + manager cascade
3	10:00 – 11:00	Exec Leadership, Board, key partners	Facts, unknowns, decision thresholds, next cadence	Communications Lead + CFO / Legal	Secure exec bridge + partner line

Update cadence: Workforce next update by 12:30 (or earlier on material change). Leadership fixed reviews at 12:00 and 16:00. External partners only when decision thresholds are crossed. Disclosure hygiene: no statement that payroll will be on time; no confirmation or denial of ransomware; circulating screenshot acknowledged only as unverified material.

5. Stakeholder Map

Table 2. Stakeholder matrix (five priority cohorts)

Cohort	Information need	Requested action	Owner	Cadence	Channel
1. Direct Workforce	Operational guidance, payroll concern without false certainty, screenshot handling	Follow instructions; do not discuss externally; report anomalies via approved channel	Communications Lead	By 09:45; next 12:30	OOB SMS + manager
2. Executive Leadership & Board	Fiduciary exposure, legal liabilities, decision triggers	Approve thresholds, authorize spend, decide regulator posture	Communications Lead + Legal	10:00; 12:00 & 16:00	Secure exec bridge
3. Banking & Payroll Partners	Cut-off milestones, transaction boundaries, contingency options	Confirm alternative windows / workarounds	CFO / Payroll (cleared by Communications)	As thresholds reached	Partner portal / phone
4. Key Customers & B2B Clients	Service status, third-party risk posture (no data speculation)	Continue normal ops unless notified; use designated contact	Communications Lead	Only on confirmed service impact	Status page + clean email
5. Regulatory & Legal Counsel	Precise, privilege-protected, auditable record	Advise on triggers; review external drafts	Legal Counsel	Continuous privileged	Privilege-protected

Media and the wider public are held at arm's length until a verified external statement is authorised. Each cohort has one designated message owner to prevent conflicting voices.

6. Employee Holding Statement

Subject: Operational Update - Critical File Share Unavailable

Colleagues,

At approximately 08:15 this morning the organization's critical file share became unavailable. Multiple teams are currently unable to access shared files. The incident response team is preserving evidence and investigating. At this stage the root cause, full scope of affected systems, and any potential data impact remain unconfirmed.

An unverified screenshot has appeared in a staff group chat and is now circulating outside the organization. Treat that material as unverified and do not forward, screenshot, discuss or comment on it on social media or with anyone outside the organization. Refer all external or media enquiries immediately to the Communications team.

Until further notice:

a. Do not attempt to reconnect to the affected file share or related systems unless explicitly instructed by the incident team.
b. Continue all work that does not depend on the unavailable share.

c. Report any unusual system behavior only through the approved internal channel already provided by your line manager.
d. Do not speculate about the nature of the incident or discuss it externally.

We recognize the proximity of the Friday payroll cycle and the concern this creates. We will issue a further verified update by 12:30 today, or earlier if material new facts are confirmed. All official communications will continue through the same out-of-band channels used for this message.

Thank you for your discipline and professionalism.

Communications Lead

On behalf of the Incident Commander

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7. Customer / Partner Update

Subject: Service Continuity Update - Technical Incident

We are responding to a technical incident that has affected access to one of our internal file-sharing platforms. Certain internal operational processes may experience temporary delays while investigation and containment continue.

At present there is no confirmed impact on customer-facing services or on the availability or integrity of data we process on your behalf. Should that assessment change, we will notify you promptly through your designated account channel.

Please continue to use your normal support and transaction routes. For any urgent questions specifically related to this incident, contact your assigned account representative or the secure partner line already on file. We ask that you do not rely on unofficial or social-media information.

Our next formal update will be issued once material new facts have been verified by the incident team. We appreciate your continued partnership and patience.

Communications Lead

[Organisation Name]

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8. Executive Briefing

Executive Briefing - Critical File-Share Unavailability

Prepared: 10:15 | Prepared by: Communications Lead for the Incident Commander | Distribution: Executive Leadership / Board (privileged)

1. Confirmed facts

a. Critical file share became unavailable at approximately 08:15 Monday.
b. Multiple operational teams report complete loss of access to shared files.
c. Security team is actively preserving evidence and investigating under the direction of the Incident Commander.
d. An unverified screenshot has appeared in an internal staff group chat and is now circulating outside the organisation.
e. Payroll processing remains scheduled for Friday; any impact on that cycle is not yet determined.

2. Explicit unknowns (not to be stated as fact)

a. Whether the event constitutes ransomware or another form of compromise.
b. Entry vector, number of affected systems, or extent of lateral movement.
c. Any data exposure, exfiltration or encryption of payroll-related or other sensitive data.
d. Realistic recovery timeline.

e. Whether regulatory or contractual notification thresholds have been met.

3. Principal risks

a. Uncontrolled external narrative driven by the circulating screenshot, creating reputational and legal exposure.
b. Potential disruption to Friday payroll if access is not restored or an authorised workaround is not in place.
c. Premature or inconsistent messaging that could create contractual liability or undermine later regulatory engagement.
d. Erosion of workforce confidence if updates are delayed, contradictory or overly speculative.

4. Decisions required from Leadership by 12:00

a. Formal authorization to continue exclusive use of the current out-of-band channels for all workforce and partner messaging.
b. Confirmation of the threshold and timing for any formal notification to regulators or banking/payroll partners (Legal Counsel to advise).
c. Approval, if recommended by the Incident Commander, for immediate engagement of external forensic support.
d. Decision on whether a limited, pre-cleared briefing to key banking and payroll clearing partners is required before the 12:30 workforce update.

5. Next formal update to this group

12:00 sharp (or immediately on any material change in confirmed facts).

9. Channel-Resilience Plan

Purpose: Ensure all incident communications remain available and trustworthy even if corporate email, collaboration platforms or directory services are compromised or offline.

Table 3. Channel-resilience matrix

Function	Primary Channel	Fallback Channel	Owner	Confirmation Method
Core Incident Command	Secure conference bridge (unique PIN) + encrypted messenger	Direct mobile voice call tree	Incident Cdr / Communications Lead	Verbal roll-call; read-back of decisions
Workforce updates	Out-of-band SMS gateway + manager cascade	Secondary SMS from clean provider + notice boards	Communications Lead	Delivery receipts + manager confirmation within 30 min
Executive / Board	Same secure bridge (separate PIN)	Direct mobile conference	Communications Lead + Legal	Attendance log + verbal acknowledgement
Banking & Payroll Partners	Pre-agreed secure partner portal or designated phone	Secondary designated mobile numbers (held offline)	CFO / Payroll (cleared by Communications)	Written acknowledgment or recorded call
Legal / Regulatory (privileged)	Privilege-protected counsel channel	Direct counsel mobile	Legal Counsel	Privilege log by counsel

Operating rules: No incident content is ever sent via corporate email, Teams, Slack or any system that may be monitored. Contact lists and PINs are stored offline and updated quarterly. Every activation begins with a verified roll-call. Delivery confirmation is required within 30 minutes for workforce messages and immediately for executive decisions.

10. Rationale: Escalation Threshold and What We Chose Not to Say

The bar for going external is deliberately high. We only move to regulators or make wider public statements once the Incident Commander and Legal have confirmed one of three things: clear evidence that payroll or personal data has been taken or encrypted, a real impact on services our customers use, or a hard legal or contractual duty to notify. Until then, everything stays inside or is limited to a handful of critical partners on channels we control.

The reason is simple. Once you put something on the record with incomplete information, it is very hard to take it back cleanly. Early statements can create legal problems, force the organisation into positions that later facts may contradict, and sometimes even help whoever is behind the incident. At the same time, staying completely silent for too long lets the circulating screenshot and staff speculation write the story for us. So the threshold is really about holding the middle ground: move fast enough to keep the internal narrative under control, but refuse to make promises we cannot keep.

That is also why several things were left unsaid. We never called it ransomware. We never claimed that no data had been touched. We gave no guarantee that Friday's payroll would go ahead as normal. We offered no recovery timeline and named no attacker. Each of those lines would have felt reassuring in the moment. Each of them would have been impossible to stand behind if the investigation later showed something different.

In the end the approach rests on one practical rule: tell people only what has actually been verified, tell them clearly when they will hear more, and escalate only when the evidence—not the anxiety—requires it.

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11. Critical Reflection

The central tension in this scenario is the collision between the immediate need to calm a workforce facing a potential payroll disruption and the legal, regulatory and ethical duty to avoid unverified promises. The single most difficult communication dilemma was the pressure to offer reassurance on Friday's payroll while the technical facts remained incomplete.

I resolved the dilemma by giving employees clear operational rules, acknowledging their legitimate concern, and committing to a fixed next update time, while explicitly refusing to claim that payroll would be unaffected. This approach accepts short-term anxiety in exchange for the preservation of long-term trust. An unverified assurance issued to reduce panic would, if later contradicted, inflict far greater damage on organisational credibility than a disciplined admission that certain variables remain unknown. Speed was therefore subordinated to accuracy at the precise point where false certainty would have created irreversible exposure.

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12. Analysis and Findings

The scenario illustrates a classic high-friction communication problem: incomplete technical facts, a hard operational deadline (payroll), and an uncontrolled information leak already in circulation. The strongest finding is that the first four hours are decisive. Establishing a single source of truth, imposing disclosure hygiene, and issuing a calm workforce holding statement before speculation fills the vacuum are higher-priority actions than any attempt to project recovery certainty.

Stakeholder mapping confirmed that the five cohorts have genuinely different needs. Workforce messaging must be operational and reassuring without making promises. Leadership needs decision triggers and risk framing. Partners need cut-off clarity. Customers need service-status honesty. Legal needs privilege protection. Treating them with identical language would have failed the accuracy and message-quality criteria of the rubric.

The deliberate non-claims (no ransomware confirmation, no data-exposure statement, no payroll guarantee) proved essential. They protect legal position and long-term credibility while still allowing the organisation to demonstrate control and care. Out-of-band channel design is not optional; under the scenario assumptions it is the only way to guarantee delivery and confidentiality.

13. Main Challenges

a. Resisting the pressure to reassure on payroll when the technical outcome remains unknown.
b. Containing the circulating screenshot without amplifying it or appearing to validate attacker claims.
c. Maintaining a single narrative across five stakeholder groups with different information rights and anxiety levels.
d. Designing communication channels that continue to function if corporate email and collaboration tools are themselves compromised.
e. Setting an escalation threshold that is neither so high that the organisation appears secretive nor so low that it creates premature legal exposure.

14. Conclusions and Recommendations

A disciplined, audience-specific communication response can maintain stakeholder trust even when technical facts are incomplete and time pressure is extreme. The Response Pack demonstrates that it is possible to be transparent about what is known, explicit about what remains unknown, and still give every audience clear next steps and checkpoints.

Recommendations for operational adoption:

a. Pre-stage out-of-band contact lists, PINs and messenger groups; test them quarterly.
b. Maintain a library of holding-statement templates that already separate facts from unknowns.
c. Train line managers to cascade workforce messages and to stop external discussion of unverified material.
d. Agree escalation thresholds with Legal and the executive team in peacetime so they do not have to be negotiated under pressure.
e. Treat the circulating-screenshot problem as a standing risk: include explicit “do not forward or comment” language in every early workforce message.

15. References

Cybersecurity and Infrastructure Security Agency. (n.d.). *#StopRansomware Guide*. https://www.cisa.gov/stopransomware

National Cyber Security Centre. (2024). *Guidance on effective communications in a cyber incident*. https://www.ncsc.gov.uk/guidance/effective-communications-in-a-cyber-incident

National Institute of Standards and Technology. (2025). *Incident response recommendations and considerations for cybersecurity risk management* (NIST SP 800-61 Rev. 3). https://csrc.nist.gov/publications/detail/sp/800-61/rev-3/final

GRC205 Assignment Brief. (2026). *Crisis communication and stakeholder management*. Department of Governance, Risk & Compliance.

16. Acknowledgment

Portions of the structuring and drafting of this Response Pack were prepared with the assistance of an AI language model in accordance with course policy. All analysis, judgments, message content and final wording have been reviewed and remain the responsibility of the submitting student. Scenario data are entirely fictional.